



“Before the pandemic, it was normal to see passengers with printouts... [but today] there is no concept of a physical ticket anymore”

India. Europe is a highly preferred destination after the US, Asia and the Middle East. We hope it remains that way for a long time. We are seeing a lot of interest from global travellers on wanting to visit Germany and the Benelux countries.

We customise our package depending on where the traveller comes from. Take the US, where they travel more often on shorter trips. Besides, if you live on the East Coast, getting to Europe does not involve too

much flight time. For Indians, travelling to Europe is more family time and could be a holiday or a honeymoon. They tend to stay longer and discover more destinations.

Q: Europe’s rail network is vast and well-connected. But there are also many changes that are taking place to widen the user base...

A: Yes, there is a lot of work that is underway. In the past, not enough was invested and today sustainability has become a big issue. Now, train travel is becoming cool and ‘flight shaming’ is taking place. It is now accepted that trains are a good mode of transport but also calls for big investments from the European Union. **Till 2030, just the EU will need to invest \$100 billion on train infrastructure.** It is a long-term project but will result in more capacity and create a better network.

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The demand for train travel is always going to be there. It is supply that needs to be created and good infrastructure will be of great help. The Eurostar (a high-speed rail service in Western Europe) was introduced in the mid-1990s with the London-Paris route. The number of flights then on that stretch was more than 300. Today, we have more people travelling but the number of flights is down to 150. It only shows what takes place when you invest in infrastructure. The preferred mode of travel for the next many decades will be train. In France, there are no domestic flights today from Paris to Lyon, where train travel takes two and a half hours.

We do 5 million tickets today, but that number can really take off. We are at 75% of pre-Covid levels. The potential is huge, and it is all about growth. Tickets are only a part of it and once you add other elements of convenience, the addressable market starts to look much larger. **BT**

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